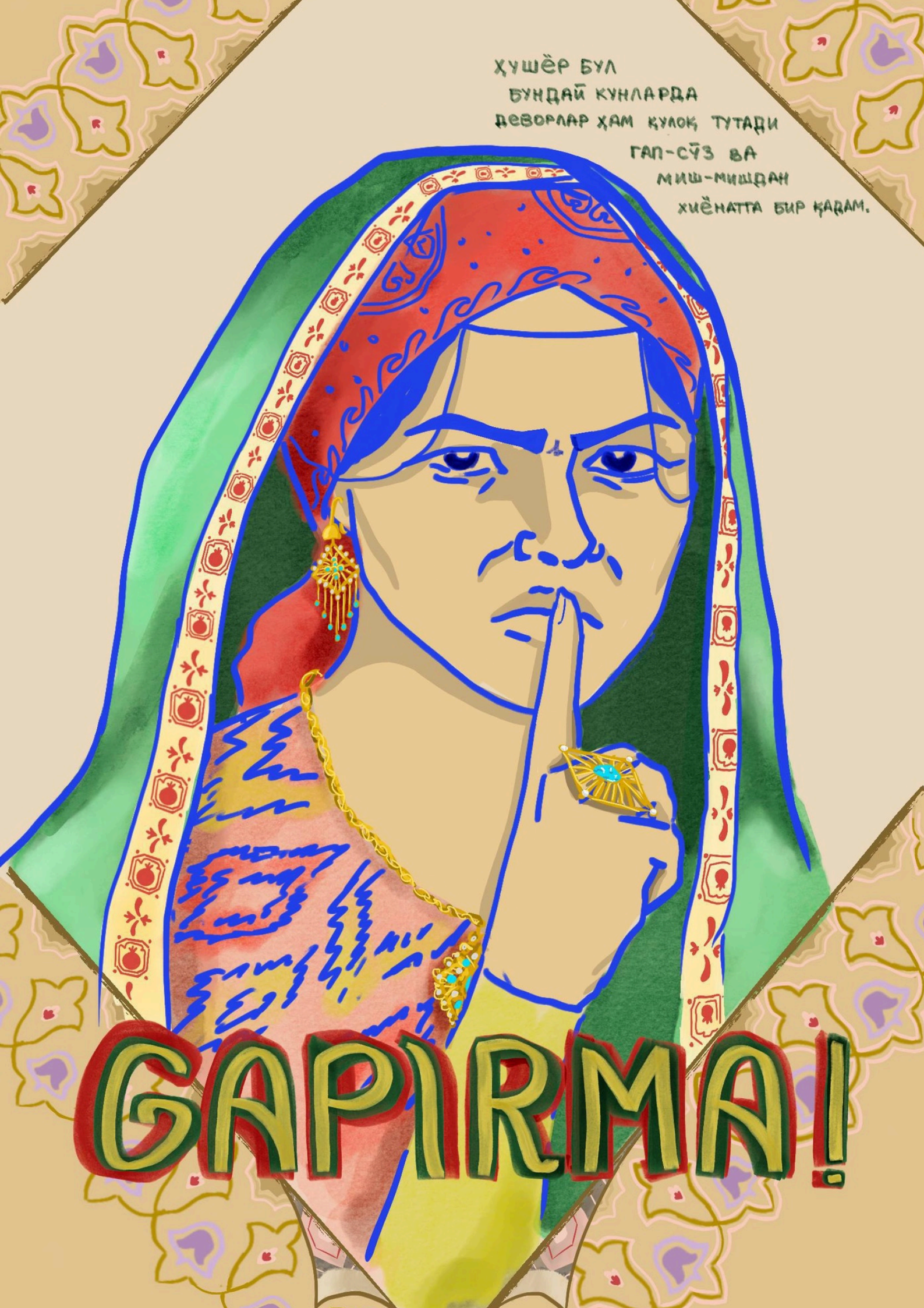

ҲУШЁР БУЛ
БУНДАЙ КУНЛАРДА
ДЕВОРЛАР ҲАМ ҚУЛОҚ ТУТАДИ
ГАП-СЎЗ ВА
МИШ-МИШДАН
ХИЁНАТГА БИР ҚАДАМ.
GAPIRMA!

Gapirma!

Karina Fatilloeva

“Не Болтай!”

The state may monitor us through documentation and technology, while society has always monitored us through gossip.

Just as passports were standardised by the League of Nations to regulate and monitor movement across borders, camera surveillance and databases are used to track the masses. But now, it is not just about borders; it is about our lifestyles and something even more important — our words.

Transparency in taxation through digital payments, security cameras for safety, and face ID seem quite convenient, as they reduce bureaucratic mess and save time. But as we give an inch, all these systems seem to take a mile.

Under the totalitarian Soviet regime, people were scared of walls. Potentially dangerous people were kept under constant observation, information streamed through the media was controlled and filtered, and all of this led to one main goal — controlling thoughts and language. Plato said, “You become what you watch,” and that is exactly what the government was trying to do (and precisely still keeps doing around the world). Even though they did not have widespread internet or cameras watching them, the wall metaphor was not figurative to say the least. Which leads me to the question: knock-knock, is 1984 really a fantasy anymore?

Yet surveillance is not always technological. In Central Asia, communities have long had their own informal systems of observation and judgment. Sadly, it is ingrained in the culture and normalised through g‘iybat and mishmish. People take one’s words and twist them to ruin their daily lives in traditional families, just as surveillance schemes twist realities against those who stand up against mass corruption and oppressive, imperialistic plans. Someone’s credibility used to depend on what people from the mahalla (a small district) would say about them. Now, it has not necessarily become worse, but certainly more complicated.

Perhaps the question is no longer whether we are being watched. Perhaps it is whether privacy, as we once understood it, ever existed at all.

Times are changing, and the only way to find out whether they are changing for better or worse is to see for yourself.